Contact

www.linkedin.com/in/lauren-knausenberger (LinkedIn)

Top Skills

Program Management
Project Management
Cross-functional Team Leadership

Certifications

PMP

Lauren Knausenberger

Fortune 500 Chief Innovation Officer | Board Member | IT Cybersecurity AI | Strategist and Venture Partner | Startup to $17B Portfolio | Former CIO at the Department of the Air Force | Speaker
Washington, District of Columbia, United States

Summary

Lauren Knausenberger is an accomplished technology, innovation, and transformation executive and board member, recognized for driving enterprise modernization, multibillion-dollar technology strategy, and mission-critical outcomes across both public- and private-sector organizations that range from $1B to $194B. She brings deep expertise in leading large-scale transformation efforts, including enterprise AI strategy, and digital modernization. Known for scanning the horizon for the next big thing and transforming organizations to meet it, she has built high-performance teams and modernized organizations. She consistently delivers impact by aligning stakeholders, scaling AI-enabled capabilities, and turning cost centers into revenue-generating operations. Lauren currently serves as a Board Member at EnerSys, where she serves on the Audit and Technology Committees. She is also an Advisory Board Member to Colossal Biosciences, a biotechnology advanced gene-editing company. Most recently, Lauren served as Chief Innovation Officer and EVP at SAIC, a $7.5B solutions provider to the U.S. government. She managed a $70M budget and led 1,500 FTEs across corporate strategy, innovation, technology, partnerships, and venture investments. She launched seven venture investments, scaled enterprise AI adoption, and delivered substantial revenue growth and cost efficiencies across commercial and mission-focused solutions. Previously, she served as CIO of the U.S. Dept of the Air Force where she oversaw a $17B global technology portfolio that spanned IT, cybersecurity, data, and AI and supported a workforce of over 20,000. There, she drove cloud adoption, moved from niche innovation projects to deliver the world's largest cloud enterprise, shepherded the DAF Zero Trust transformation for over 700,000 global users, launched and scaled Digital U, which provides access to best-in-class learning, streamlined security accreditation, and scaled software delivery at speed. Earlier in her career, she held roles across Accelint, NextGen Venture Partners, and CACI, where

she drove significant business expansion, innovation frameworks, and operational transformation. She is a sought-after keynote on AI, cybersecurity, and digital transformation. Her honors include Global CIO of the Year, Fed 100, Wash 100, and multiple recognitions as a top woman in technology. She maintains an active TS/SCI clearance and spends her free time with her husband and two daughters flying on their small plane and traveling internationally for history, adventure, and culinary experiences.

Experience

EnerSys
Board Member
August 2024 - Present (2 years)

A $3.7B publicly traded global leader in stored energy solutions that provides industrial batteries, chargers, and energy systems that support telecommunications, data centers, transportation, and defense.

– Independent Director, Audit Committee Member, Tech Committee Member

NextGen Venture Partners
Venture Partner
April 2016 - Present (10 years 4 months)
Washington, DC

NextGen Venture Partners is a network-driven venture capital firm that utilizes a community of executives, founders, and innovators—to source deals, conduct due diligence, and provide hands-on operational support to high-growth technology startups ready for pre-seed, seed, and growth funding.

SAIC
Chief Innovation Officer / Executive Vice President
September 2023 - February 2026 (2 years 6 months)

A $7B publicly traded technology integrator that provides engineering, digital transformation, and mission solutions primarily to U.S. government agencies in the defense, intelligence, and civilian sectors. Led corporate strategy and implementation planning for enterprise IT, mission IT, and engineering. Served on the executive leadership team with a ~$70M budget and 1,500 FTEs across technology, the CTO Office, the innovation organization, corporate strategy, capability development and innovation, strategic partnerships, venture investments, and agile software delivery.

– Ran the commercial arm of the company; executed major integration and modernization initiatives across AI, digital engineering, cloud, and cybersecurity to reduce sustainment costs, streamline delivery, and strengthen solution maturity.
– Led a $150M P&L, built and launched commercial offerings, delivered 3X high-margin growth, secured significant improvements in technical win rates, and certified monthly financial performance.
– Cut $30M in costs out of the Chief Innovation Office while shifting to a revenue producing center that increased revenue by $20M in under six months.
– Led the enterprise AI strategy, digital modernization, and full-lifecycle solution development across the business and for clients
– Led the restructuring of an enterprise IT capabilities service organization with 1,200 FTEs, delivered value, overhauled processes, and launched AI tools to reduce costs by almost half.
– Took over SAIC's mission advisory practice; delivered 5X revenue and 50% cost savings through new tooling, rightsizing headcount, and designing automation processes that leveraged AI and Agentic capabilities.
– Launched SAIC Ventures and led deals that achieved 2X and 5X returns on the first two exits in under two years with cybersecurity and quantum companies.
– Regularly briefed the board of directors.

Department of the Air Force

6 years 1 month

Chief Information Officer (SES)

August 2020 - June 2023 (2 years 11 months)

Selected to serve as a three-star equivalent civilian and lead at $17B portfolio, including enterprise IT, data and AI, cybersecurity, and technology and innovation for the Department and support 20,000 global personnel.
– Led the DAF IT investment strategy from networks to cloud computing, enterprise policies, data management, digital transformation, information resources management, information technology innovation initiatives, and information to integrate warfighting and mission support capabilities.
Ensured the cybersecurity of the enterprise and defended against over one million daily attacks.
– Led the strategy, capabilities investment, and training to oversee the ethical use of AI across the DAF.

– Led talent management for 10,000 IT/cybersecurity civilian personnel across all HR facets, from recruiting to professional development.
Scaled and reached enterprise saturation for the Digital University, which reached over 215,000 learners with 25% daily usage.
– Led the modernization of DAF technology systems and cut legacy programs to trade space for innovative projects while buying down the technology debt.
– Drove cloud adoption and moved from niche innovation to delivering the world's largest cloud enterprise.
– Pioneered the DAF Zero Trust transformation; architected a comprehensive roadmap to transition from perimeter based security for over 700,000 global users.

Chief Transformation Officer / Director of Cyberspace Innovation
June 2017 - August 2020 (3 years 3 months)

Hired as a one-star equivalent civilian to lead rapid adoption of commercial technologies and practices, remove roadblocks to innovation, and drive policy change related to IT transformation. Served as a member of the CIO executive team and worked closely with CIO, Air Combat Command, 16th Air Force Cyber Command, acquisition, and others to develop strategy and messaging, drive priorities, maintain cross-organizational relationships, and lead high impact transformation projects.
– Led first-of-its kind innovation to unite DevSecOps community (Kessel Run and other software factories), tie best practices to accreditation, and drive adoption of open/inner source coding.
– Architected and led the Fast Track Authority to Operate (ATO and cATO) efforts, which allowed high performing software development teams to deploy new applications and capabilities to the warfighter instantaneously, without additional manual human accreditation.
– Drove Enterprise IT as a service (EITaaS), Cloud One, the DAF enterprise cloud, Platform One, the DAF DevOps platform, and bring your own approved device (BYOAD) to enable Airmen to access data anywhere.
– Led a cultural change to “get to yes” rather than simply admiring the complexities of roadblocks.
– Launched and scaled Platform One, a standard launching point for most DAF development teams.
– Launched the Spark Tank program, a DAF-wide program to identify and fund the best Airmen and Guardian mission focused innovative product; recruited senior DAF leaders and celebrities like Mark Cuban, which led to an innovative leadership culture and empowered teams to solve problems.

– Launched Digital University to democratize access to best-in class-digital learning, gamified the experience, and operationalized the platform to drive future career path decisions, placements, mentorship, special projects, and other retention incentives.
– Recognized as a major contributor in the NIST guidance for reforming the DAF cybersecurity processes.

AFWERX
Director of Spark Tank
November 2017 - August 2020 (2 years 10 months)

Accellint, Inc.
President and CEO
May 2014 - October 2018 (4 years 6 months)

Accellint, Inc. is an advisory practice and capital investor that helps start-ups and established defense technology businesses, bringing together technology and national security to enter markets, grow business, and raise capital.

– Led all business operations, management, and growth for the start-up government consulting firm. Consulted with small and mid-sized businesses regarding strategic planning, technical solutions, and market analysis in pursuit of strategic opportunities and growth in the defense and intelligence space.
– Provided business plan development support, strategic planning, and ongoing consulting for a start-up tech firm in the Intelligence Community (IC) space; enabled the firm to grow to over 40 FTEs and $10M in revenue within the first two years and launch a PE investment arm to incubate new technologies.
– Provided process improvement and consulting support to a large consulting firm; supported the change of their financial data analysis strategy that reduced manpower and duration by 20%.
– Developed an innovation framework that allowed government agencies to use lessons learned from PE and VC investors to more quickly bring commercially viable innovative technologies into government.
– Provided an entry strategy for an existing cyber-focused small business to enter the IC space; the firm has grown by nearly 5X to 100 people with 20% of its business in the IC.
– Conducted a capabilities and market analysis for an Iowa-based cyber startup, advised them on the successful strategy for commercial viability in local markets, before entering the government space.

– Advised a university lab-based cyber start-up on tailoring their model for commercial viability and helped them raise $1M in seed funding and secure a spot in a cyber accelerator.
– Provided thought leadership connecting partners to develop innovative solutions to pressing defense and intelligence challenges that leveraged both the public and private best practices.

Graphene Frontiers
Angel Investor and Advisor
November 2012 - December 2017 (5 years 2 months)
Greater Philadelphia Area

Graphene frontiers is a world-leading developer of graphene sensors and electronics.

CACI International Inc
Division Manager
July 2004 - October 2015 (11 years 4 months)

American Management Systems (AMS)
Business Analyst
June 2003 - July 2004 (1 year 2 months)

ANSER Corporation
Space Analysis
June 2000 - January 2001 (8 months)

United States Department of Defense
INFOSEC/SIGINT
June 1998 - August 1999 (1 year 3 months)

Education

University of Pennsylvania - The Wharton School
Master of Business Administration (M.B.A.) · (2010 - 2012)

Harvard Kennedy School
The Intersection of Policy and Technology

University of Maryland College Park
Bachelor of Science (BS), Decision and Information Sciences